

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY



ATTACK REPORT

Gopher Strike and Sheet Attack Campaigns Targeting Indian Government

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A1

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Summary

First Seen: September 2025

Targeted Region: India

Targeted Platform: Windows

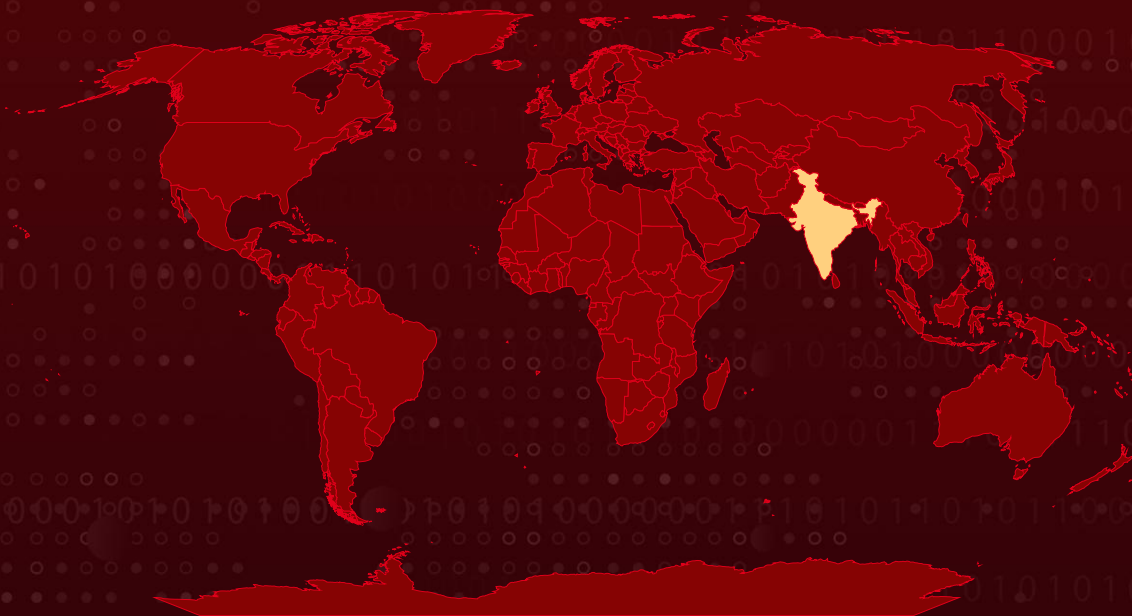
Targeted Industry: Government

Malware: GOGITTER, GITSHELLPAD, GOSHELL, SHEETCREEP, FIREPOWER, MAILCREEP

Campaigns: Gopher Strike and Sheet Attack

Attack: A Pakistan-linked threat actor launched two parallel cyber-espionage campaigns, Gopher Strike and Sheet Attack, targeting Indian government entities by blending social engineering with cloud-native command-and-control to remain hidden in plain sight. The operations begin with weaponized PDFs masquerading as official documents and fake Adobe updates, selectively delivering payloads only to Indian Windows systems to evade automated analysis. Gopher Strike abuses private GitHub repositories to deploy Golang-based loaders and backdoors that culminate in hands-on intrusion and Cobalt Strike activity, while Sheet Attack leverages trusted services such as Google Sheets, Firebase, and Microsoft Graph for command execution, data theft, and exfiltration. The combination of novel tooling, cloud service abuse, and interactive post-compromise behavior, alongside signs of AI-assisted development, signals a notable evolution beyond classic APT36 tradecraft, suggesting a parallel Pakistan-aligned espionage operation operating with greater precision and stealth.

✂ Attack Regions



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Targeted

Non-Targeted



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Attack Details

#1

In September 2025, two parallel cyber-espionage campaigns, tracked as Gopher Strike and Sheet Attack, were observed targeting Indian government entities. Both operations are attributed to a Pakistan-linked threat actor and show partial overlaps with APT36, while introducing new tools and tactics. The attacks begin with spear-phishing emails carrying malicious PDF files that mimic official government documents, overlaid with fake Adobe update prompts. Payload delivery is tightly controlled through server-side checks that validate Indian IP ranges and Windows user agents, effectively filtering out sandboxes and automated scanners.

#2

Gopher Strike relies heavily on GitHub for command-and-control. Victims are lured into downloading an ISO file that drops GOGITTER, a Golang-based downloader that establishes persistence via a VBScript and a scheduled task disguised as a Microsoft Edge update. GOGITTER pulls the GITSHELLPAD backdoor from private GitHub repositories, using embedded tokens and GitHub's REST API for two-way C2. In high-value intrusions, the actor escalates to GOSHELL, an unusually large Golang shellcode loader designed to evade detection, which ultimately deploys a stageless Cobalt Strike Beacon using a jQuery-style Malleable C2 profile.

#3

The Sheet Attack campaign takes a different route by abusing trusted cloud platforms. Early variants deploy SHEETCREEP, a C# backdoor that uses Google Sheets as its C2 channel, encrypting traffic with TripleDES and executing commands through hidden command-line processes. Newer iterations shift to malicious LNK files delivering FIREPOWER, a PowerShell backdoor that communicates via Google Firebase. Select targets also receive MAILCREEP, a Golang backdoor abusing Microsoft Graph API within an attacker-controlled Azure tenant, alongside a document-stealing PowerShell script that exfiltrates sensitive files to private GitHub repositories.

#4

Across both campaigns, the operator demonstrates strong operational security and active hands-on-keyboard activity, including observable command-line mistakes during post-compromise actions. Malware analysis also points to the likely use of generative AI in development, reflected in verbose Unicode comments and emoji-laden error handling. While victim profiles, infrastructure traits, and some tooling align with APT36, the consistent use of novel backdoors, cloud-native C2 channels, and refined evasion techniques suggests this activity may represent a distinct subgroup, or a parallel Pakistan-linked operation running alongside traditional APT36 campaigns.

Recommendations



Block Malicious Domains and IPs: Implement immediate blocking of all identified C2 domains including adobe-acrobat[.]in, adobereader-upgrade[.]in, adobecloud[.]site, govt-filessharing[.]site, hciaccounts[.]in, hcisupport[.]in, hcidelhi[.]in, hcidoc[.]in, and coadelhi[.]in at network perimeter and DNS levels.



Monitor GitHub API Communications: Implement monitoring and alerting for unusual GitHub API traffic patterns, particularly authentication token usage and repository interactions from endpoints that typically do not require such access.



Restrict Cloud Service Access: Apply strict egress filtering for Google Sheets API, Firebase Realtime Database, and Microsoft Graph API connections from sensitive government network segments, permitting only authorized business applications.



Implement Application Allowlisting: Deploy application control policies preventing execution of unsigned Golang binaries and PowerShell scripts from user-writable directories.



Implement Zero Trust Network Architecture: Segment government networks to limit lateral movement capabilities if initial compromise occurs, particularly isolating systems with access to sensitive documents.



Review Third-Party Cloud Service Policies: Audit organizational policies regarding GitHub, Google, Firebase, and Microsoft cloud service usage to identify legitimate baseline activity and detect anomalous access patterns.



Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

Tactic	Technique	Sub-technique
Resource Development	T1583: Acquire Infrastructure	T1583.001: Domains
		T1583.006: Web Services
	T1585: Establish Accounts	T1585.003: Cloud Accounts
	T1587: Develop Capabilities	T1587.001: Malware
		T1588.007: Artificial Intelligence
	T1588: Obtain Capabilities	T1588.002: Tool
		T1588.007: Artificial Intelligence
	T1608: Stage Capabilities	T1608.001: Upload Malware
Initial Access	T1566: Phishing	T1566.002: Spearphishing Link
Execution	T1059: Command and Scripting Interpreter	T1059.001: PowerShell
		T1059.003: Windows Command Shell
		T1059.005: Visual Basic
	T1106: Native API	
	T1204: User Execution	T1204.001: Malicious Link
	T1129: Shared Modules	
Persistence	T1053: Scheduled Task/Job	T1053.005: Scheduled Task



Tactic	Technique	Sub-technique
Defense Evasion	<u>T1027</u> : Obfuscated Files or Information	<u>T1027.001</u> : Binary Padding
		<u>T1027.013</u> : Encrypted/Encoded File
		<u>T1027.009</u> : Embedded Payloads
		<u>T1027.015</u> : Compression
	<u>T1036</u> : Masquerading	<u>T1036.004</u> : Masquerade Task or Service
		<u>T1036.005</u> : Match Legitimate Resource Name or Location
		<u>T1036.008</u> : Masquerade File Type
	<u>T1055</u> : Process Injection	<u>T1055.004</u> : Asynchronous Procedure Call
	<u>T1140</u> : Deobfuscate/Decode Files or Information	
	<u>T1480</u> : Execution Guardrails	<u>T1480.001</u> : Environmental Keying
	<u>T1553</u> : Subvert Trust Controls	<u>T1553.005</u> : Mark-of-the-Web Bypass
	<u>T1070</u> : Indicator Removal	<u>T1070.004</u> : File Deletion
Discovery	<u>T1564</u> : Hide Artifacts	<u>T1564.003</u> : Hidden Window
	<u>T1620</u> : Reflective Code Loading	
	<u>T1016</u> : System Network Configuration Discovery	<u>T1016.001</u> : Internet Connection Discovery
	<u>T1033</u> : System Owner/User Discovery	
	<u>T1057</u> : Process Discovery	
	<u>T1087</u> : Account Discovery	<u>T1087.001</u> : Local Account
		<u>T1087.002</u> : Domain Account
	<u>T1018</u> : Remote System Discovery	

Tactic	Technique	Sub-technique
Discovery	<u>T1082</u> : System Information Discovery	
Collection	<u>T1560</u> : Archive Collected Data	<u>T1560.003</u> : Archive via Custom Method
		<u>T1560.002</u> : Archive via Library
	<u>T1530</u> : Data from Cloud Storage	
Command and Control	<u>T1071</u> : Application Layer Protocol	<u>T1071.001</u> : Web Protocols
	<u>T1102</u> : Web Service	<u>T1102.002</u> : Bidirectional Communication
		<u>T1102.001</u> : Dead Drop Resolver
	<u>T1105</u> : Ingress Tool Transfer	
	<u>T1132</u> : Data Encoding	<u>T1132.001</u> : Standard Encoding
	<u>T1573</u> : Encrypted Channel	<u>T1573.001</u> : Symmetric Cryptography
		<u>T1573.002</u> : Asymmetric Cryptography
	<u>T1665</u> : Hide Infrastructure	
	<u>T1008</u> : Fallback Channels	
Exfiltration	<u>T1567</u> : Exfiltration Over Web Service	<u>T1567.001</u> : Exfiltration to Code Repository

✂ Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
MD5	b531b8d72561cb5c88d97986e450bbae, 8577f613b3aec5c1c90118b15eea8756, c876a70380738236ee28aab60a2cde6e, 9b9c574cdb17c238df80414476228a78, f2a71b2719744765ac8a6a49b2acbce6, 0d86b8039cffc384856e17912f308616, f454e2724a63cbbfda26daff1d8bb610, 10a7725f807056cb0383a1cae38d49b4, e26b3fece2fe296654406ef8045ffda1, f4813d65cd7246f716fcbd8f7fd3e63d, f2284f62625f117c57384b1c5b8b8f58, 87c7d69c6131406afdd0a08e89329d0a, 62a23220b0249a15503f5ad762ed5889, 03141afe5c20d37620c085cdbeeb4058b, 21dacb6cf6da872f1f3c7b6c876a8a92, 6bed5e271eddf5cb86a5964b8c2f51b6, 1ede39cb02b8aaa75063febc167db565, 0729db72ab4ad9b2ac7a82918c744388, 7269779e3fe07b1d96564117461ec75b, f9a2da8f12179414663a230f11edca20, 12669c29e00057abf20c73a434eb3dd2, cd5aab2b0f8d2b42e7a6537303d6345d, 0f7730a78490c61964b3bfc05eb59ea7, 119b836b4e1e7be8c3be8fe921f72bfb, 41a3752e6ea83d25731f22e1c17f59e2, 12669c29e00057abf20c73a434eb3dd2, e48f1000c86b93cf428a13a0b7384e0d, a0b6869accba2c9ad3e1f79268a810d4, 556a567a2c5c27a6aa5660e2e6bcce7b, 5001c32b386cc8346079db7b2629d777, ed4dd29c57a38f2bb1934acbaeadeeba
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TYPE	VALUE
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TYPE	VALUE
SHA256	43fb05d9fc179f791b1a2814f7116ee577b6e48f62eee63af039350260 d7fe2b, bec00fa5a87195f182511ecc5292a716c79bc74e17bd1138c8fb2f2285 df1b46, 59abb997927e471472a1c487dea0180d11e9c99774bb138ace46771a cba9c3d8, 363fca9534e5cb69e40330473bcb0acc439cf81a555234eed250f65c9 8478e3, 71794df37a107472e8d0829387741953f9e6c7778519b11f061c79ff6f b0f386, eea5cb7795d86e4612edcc6f0085d151e1b7a7351646caf26955c2ac3 5158971, 9eebbf8899a1cf4156a872e9b8cde2a8f6ab364b8089550510938405c 622cc58, 889b4b1e13b66aff349282eae3999783f5542f961b433a7d4653c5281 e7f4d3e, 20d72c8580b4d5ef4f771c91ce1d1207e5416fa789d8216a73a0abb8e 030644f, de14ca6d93dadbc1ec216700d76ad2d0e7b9ebceb95de68c631d0a1c 01c915c4, 644dda0ea5db1eb5f07ccfccddb909c6ee57235c4465adbfc342da6867 cdb71a, 309a39ba10cd7c7075837b63d247fa45764f5496fdae215e95a3f4b65 ab6dfc3, 889b4b1e13b66aff349282eae3999783f5542f961b433a7d4653c5281 e7f4d3e, 989ad43bb9e328d786664247c3af4c17be28932760113708a9c6de97 7d69652c, 86d8b3fe209b3f1d9a20865ff1ee5d6015941c2a5394861118c8d6ec3 695f1a6, bb11bea463ab1b976c3716591f93eccc71c1a2d1c389a371416b140cd 8faa6f0, 61b2b6b61474398a966e26d3b909542450fcab9b6670558cecd6fabc1 015bbce, a97cc81a2f7c05bfc498b71999176c2aeb6e3ad273e48eb1f5c1c56474 19c642
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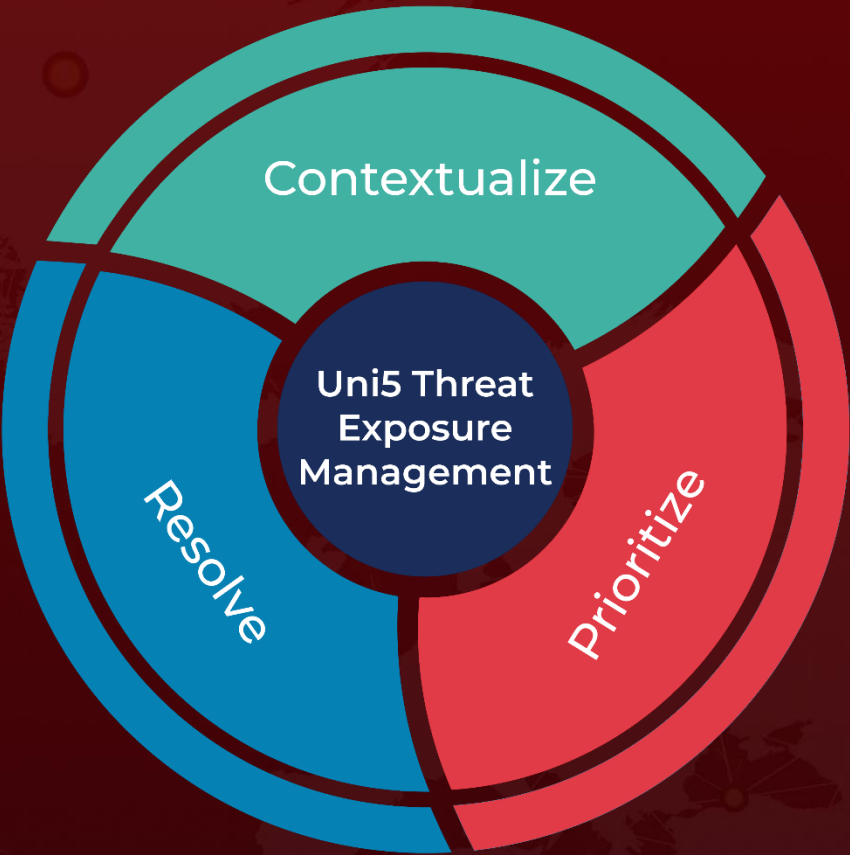
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